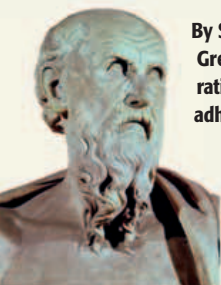




BEFORE



By Socrates' time (see right), Greek thinkers had begun to seek rational explanations, instead of adhering to traditional beliefs.

GREEK MYTHOLOGY

Homer's epics << 102–03

of the 8th century BCE, retelling legends from Greek prehistory, underpinned all later classical education.

Hesiod's poem *Theogony*, ("birth of the gods") c. 700 BCE, gives the first systematic account of Greek mythology, whose many gods were consulted through divination and oracles, such as the famous oracle at the Temple of Apollo in Delphi. Pre-Socratic philosophers questioned these traditional beliefs.

Xenophanes (c. 570 BCE) wrote: "Homer and Hesiod have attributed to the gods everything that is shameful and blameworthy among men."



CONSULTING THE DELPHIC ORACLE

TRADING WISDOM

From about the middle of the 7th century BCE, the Greek world was transformed << 94–95 as a commercial economy developed, with the market place, the *agora*, as the center of social life in every city. Exposure to new ideas through trade inspired thinkers to challenge traditional wisdom. Greeks exchanged social, political, and philosophical ideas and dared to imagine novel ways of governing society and of understanding the world. Anaximenes (c. 585 BCE) thought the origin of everything was air; Heraclitus (c. 534 BCE) thought it was fire << 104–05.

THE FOUNDERS

The Greeks recognized **seven sages** as founders of their intellectual tradition. The names varied but always included **Solon of Athens** (c. 630 BCE) << 100–01, whose maxim was "nothing in excess," and **Thales of Miletus** (c. 640 BCE) << 104–05, the first true philosopher. According to Plato, the other five were **Bias** of Priene, **Chilon** of Sparta, **Cleobulus** of Lindos, **Myson** of Chenae, and **Pittacus** of Mytilene.

"...the unexamined life is **not worth living...**"

SOCRATES, SPEAKING AT HIS TRIAL, 399 BCE

The School of Athens

This painting by Raphael—painted in 1509 for Pope Julius II—is proof of the enduring influence of Plato and Aristotle (walking in the center) and Socrates (leaving the picture on the left) on Western philosophy.

